

Keynote Address by the Minister of Public Service and Administration PSCBC

Strategic Planning Session Theme: *Collective Bargaining in the Digital Era: Building Trust, Managing Disputes, and Ensuring Good Governance*

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Venue: Radisson Hotel & Convention Centre, Johannesburg

Greetings

Honourable Chairperson and the General Secretary of the PSCBC, distinguished members of the Public Service Co-ordinating Bargaining Council, esteemed labour and employer representatives, colleagues, and guests:

Introduction: A New Frontier for Labour Relations

Good morning. It is a profound honour to stand before the architects of peace and productivity in our public service. I extend my heartfelt gratitude to the PSCBC for this privilege. Your work in advancing labour relations in the public service is a cornerstone of a functioning democracy. It is through your dedication, dialogue, and commitment that the rights of employees are protected, and the obligations of the public service are fulfilled.

We gather at a pivotal moment. The world of work is no longer a distant future we are "preparing" for; it is the reality we live in today. As we convene here, we must recognize that the traditional corridors of collective bargaining are being reshaped by the digital revolution. The world is changing rapidly technological innovation, digital transformation, and new ways of working are reshaping our public service and the broader labour environment. It is therefore fitting that our discussions are framed by the theme: "Collective Bargaining in the Digital Era: Building Trust, Managing Disputes, and Ensuring Good Governance. This theme is not merely symbolic; it reflects the challenges and opportunities that lie before us as we seek to modernize our systems while preserving the human and institutional foundations of labour relations.

Our task over the next three days is to ensure that while our tools change, our core values trust, fairness, and the dignity of the public servant remain unshakeable.

Navigating the Digital Era: Trust and Innovation

The theme of this session: *Building Trust, Managing Disputes, and Ensuring Good Governance* is particularly timely.

Digital transformation offers us a "Double-Edged Sword":

1. **The Opportunity:** We can use technology to make dispute resolution faster and more accessible. Imagine a public service where a grievance doesn't languish in paperwork for months, but is tracked, managed, and resolved through transparent, digital platforms.
2. **The Challenge:** Digitalization can feel impersonal. It can create "data silos" or exacerbate feelings of surveillance.

On one hand, technology can create complexity, uncertainty, and new forms of workplace tension. On the other hand, it offers immense potential to modernize operations, improve efficiency, and enhance collaboration.

To bridge this gap, we must leverage innovation to enhance operational efficiency without losing the "human touch" that is essential to mediation and negotiations.

It is our responsibility to harness technology thoughtfully. Digital platforms can streamline communication, automate routine processes, and provide tools for data-driven decision-making. They can support training, enhance dispute management, and facilitate remote engagement where needed. Yet, we must always remember that technology is a tool, not a substitute for human judgment, empathy, and dialogue the core elements of successful collective bargaining.

By integrating innovation responsibly, we can create a public service that is adaptive, efficient, and equipped to meet the demands of the 21st century, while preserving the integrity of our labour relations institutions.

Reaffirming the Centrality of Collective Bargaining

First and foremost, let us be clear: Collective bargaining is not a hurdle to be cleared; it is the cornerstone of a stable democracy. In an era of rapid change, the PSCBC serves as the vital anchor that prevents industrial instability. Our commitment to this institution is absolute. However, "protecting" collective bargaining does not mean keeping it static. It means evolving our processes so they can withstand the pressures of a modern economy and a digitally enabled workforce.

At the heart of this Strategic Planning Session is the reaffirmation of collective bargaining as the foundation of public service labour relations. Collective bargaining is not just a mechanism for negotiation it is a process through which trust is built, mutual understanding is fostered, and sustainable agreements are reached. It enables employers and employees to work together to achieve outcomes that are fair, balanced, and in the public interest.

In a sector as critical as the public service, where the stakes are high and the impact on citizens' lives is direct, maintaining a robust collective bargaining framework is essential. It ensures that disputes are addressed constructively, that the workplace remains harmonious, and that service delivery is not compromised.

Strengthening Dispute Management

As the Minister, my message to this Council is simple: Our dispute management mechanisms must be beyond reproach. They must be timely, they must be fair, and most importantly, their outcomes must be sustainable. We are not just resolving a "case"; we are maintaining the morale of the men and women who keep our hospitals running, our schools open, and our borders secure.

One of the key priorities for this session is strengthening dispute management mechanisms. Timely, fair, and sustainable resolution of disputes is essential not only to maintain operational efficiency, but also to safeguard trust and confidence in public service institutions.

Disputes, if left unresolved, can erode relationships, stall service delivery, and create environments of tension and uncertainty. Through enhanced mechanisms such as

early intervention strategies, improved communication channels, and capacity building for negotiators we can ensure that conflicts are addressed efficiently and equitably.

Governance

We cannot have "Good Governance" without Accountability and Transparency. Equally critical is the principle of good governance. Transparency, accountability, and inclusivity are not just abstract ideals they are the operational principles that guide every effective institution. Across PSCBC structures, embedding these principles will ensure that decisions are informed, stakeholder voices are heard, and outcomes are credible and legitimate.

In a democratic public service, good governance also means that we lead by example. Decisions must be evidence-based, processes must be open, and responsibility must be shared. Only then can we foster confidence among employees, employer, and the public at large.

A Shared Roadmap for the Future

Over these three days, you will develop 5 years roadmap that aligns the priorities of both employers and labour. This roadmap must not be a "wish list" for one side or a "constraint list" for the other. Collaboration by parties is key. It requires listening, negotiating, and compromise but most importantly, it requires a shared vision of the public service we seek to build: one that is equitable, accountable, efficient, and responsive to the needs of citizens.

The priorities of the Employer and Labour are often viewed as opposing forces. I challenge you to view them as two sides of the same coin:

- The Employer wants efficiency and fiscal sustainability.
- Labour wants fair compensation and decent working conditions.

In the digital era, these goals converge at productivity and labour peace. By embracing technology and good governance, we can create a public service that delivers more

for our citizens while providing a more fulfilling and equitable environment for our workers.

Your deliberations over the coming days should aim to not only address immediate concerns, but also to create structures and frameworks that will guide the PSCBC into the future. By combining strategic foresight with practical, actionable plans, you will ensure that the public service remains a model of effective governance and labour harmony.

In Conclusion

As you begin your deliberations, I urge you to be bold. Do not fear the digital shift, direct it. Do not avoid the difficult conversations, embrace them as the only path to genuine trust.

The employees, trade union members and citizens of South Africa are watching. They depend on the stability that this Council provides. Let us give them a public service that is modern, ethical, and built on a foundation of unbreakable social dialogue.

I wish you a productive and transformative Strategic Planning Session.

In conclusion, I want to emphasize three guiding principles as you embark on these discussions:

Trust: The foundation of all effective collective bargaining lies in trust. Nurture it, protect it, and ensure it guides every decision.

Innovation: Embrace technology and innovation, but always in service of human-centred, equitable labour relations.

Governance: Uphold the highest standards of transparency, accountability, and inclusivity in every aspect of your work.

I have every confidence that this Strategic Planning Session will be productive, forward-looking, and transformative. I look forward to seeing the ideas, strategies, and solutions you develop, and to witnessing the PSCBC continue to strengthen collective bargaining in the public service.

With that, it is my honour to officially declare the 2026 PSCBC Strategic Planning Session open. I wish you fruitful deliberations, constructive engagement, and meaningful outcomes.

Thank you